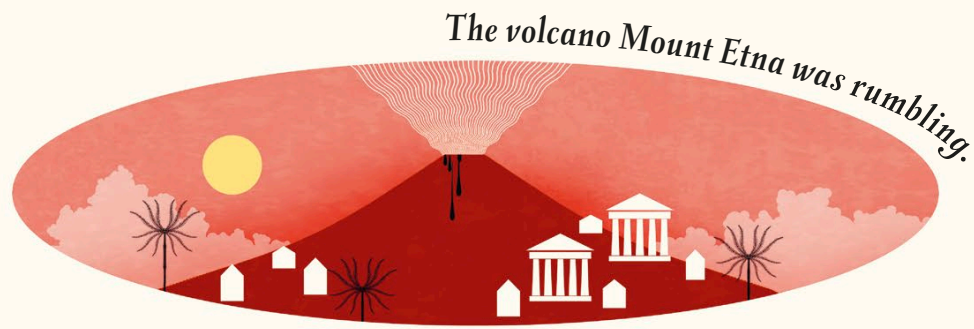




*Persephone was the daughter of proud Zeus, king of the gods, and kind Demeter, goddess of the harvest. She was a gentle girl, who lived with her mother on the island of Sicily.*

There, she helped Demeter tend to the Earth and make plants grow. However, Sicily was also home to the great volcano Mount Etna. One afternoon, when Persephone was out walking in the countryside, the volcano began to rumble. Smoke streamed from its crater and powerful tremors caused the ground to crack wide open.

*Persephone stumbled back from the fracture in the ground in surprise.*

Hades saw what was happening from the underworld and raced to the surface in his chariot to inspect the fracture. "I must seal this new entrance to my kingdom," he thought, "but wait... who is that?" When he caught sight of the lovely Persephone, Hades fell in love instantly. "She must be my wife!" he decided. Seizing his chance, Hades rode by Persephone and pulled her into the chariot beside him. They went back through the opening, and the earth closed behind them. On the ground, it was as if nothing had happened.